THE TRUTH REMAINED UNDER A ROOF TILE

One of Kurt Gerstein's desperate attempts to alert the world failed in the Netherlands. An eyewitness account from Treblinka intended for the illegal newspaper Trouw on March 25, 1943, reached no further than the village of Sinderen in the Achterhoek. There, it was hidden under a roof tile of a chicken coop. Ben van Kaam investigated why that shocking news was never published in Trouw.

BEN VAN KAAM July 22, 1995, 00:00

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After the war, Jo Satter took a look at the place where he used to live. Behind the ruins, he saw the small shed that had been spared, lifted a roof tile, and found the document there that Dr. L. de Jong would later refer to as 'the only report in our country that described exactly what happened in the Polish extermination camps.' Why was that not published in Trouw at the time? The story begins in the spring of 1941 when JH Ubbink in Doesburg receives a phone call from an old friend from the German Christian Student Association, who is stationed in Arnhem: 'May I visit you?' 'You always,' Ubbink says spontaneously. “But I am in an SS uniform,” warns Kurt Gerstein. However, Ubbink knows Gerstein too well not to suspect that there must be something behind this. Several times Gerstein travels to Doesburg to speak with his old friend about what moves him, once even for a whole weekend. Dressed in borrowed civilian clothes, he goes to church with Ubbink. Together they listen to the

lose this war; better a hundredfold Versailles than for this gang of criminals to remain. What good is it to a people when it conquers the whole world and suffers damage to its soul?" Yet Ubbink has to swallow something when it turns out Gerstein has been promoted to SS officer in the summer of 1942. He has doubts about this approach, but not about his friend's intentions. In February 1943, Ubbink encounters a desperate Kurt Gerstein in Berlin. Six months earlier, he had already witnessed what was happening in Belzec and Treblinka when the SS leadership wanted to use his technical knowledge to speed up the gassings, but all his attempts to alert the world prove fruitless. No one is doing anything. Ubbink: "Initially, I did not want to believe him, but his great excitement and his mental breakdown convinced me, even more than what he swore, that a secret was being communicated to me here from the darkest corners of the National Socialist enterprise. He asked me if I could get in touch with people who were in radio contact with England. Upon my affirmative answer, he asked—no, rather, he implored—that I pass the story on to England, so that it would be made public and so that the German people, too, would be enlightened. I promised him that." Ubbink kept that promise, but unlike Gerstein, Ubbink expected little from the effect of publicity. He limits himself strictly to the promise he made to Kurt Gerstein. That was to 'pass on' his communications to persons who had contact with the Allies. But beyond that, he made—by his own account—little effort for further publication. He does believe, however, that Gerstein told him the truth. "Personally, I have never doubted that," he writes to Mrs. Gerstein on January 31, 1947.In Doesburg, resistance members regularly visit Ubbink—from the AR side, he believed—whom he only knows by their aliases. He informs one of them, presumably without mentioning Gerstein's name and without making any mention of his trip to Berlin. When Dr. L. de Jong sends a photograph of Van de Hooft to Ubbink, who had emigrated to Canada, twenty years later, he recognizes him. "We called him Cor." The origin of the document is thus established. And so we know fairly accurately which facts must have reached, among others, the

time. To this day, the archives regarding the Gerstein reports have remained tightly closed. We know the rest of the story from Jo Satter, a member of the Trouw group. In early January 1968, the resistance fighter who died in 1988 told me: “I can still see Cor sitting there writing. He was actually completely shaken by it. My father, who later died from the consequences of the concentration camp, was there too. When Cor was finished, he said: ‘This is such a terrible thing; you must read this.’” Naturally, Cor van de Hooft did not tell father and son Satter how he obtained the information. Jo Satter always believed that Cor had just spoken to the German himself and that the latter must therefore be nearby. The piece also gave that impression. In *Trouw* news bulletins of March 1947, Cor van de Hooft, who did not return from the concentration camp, was characterized as a cautious man. The son of a Reformed minister and civil servant from Overschie knew how to keep silent. He was involved in espionage work from an early age. After his group was rounded up in 1942, he ended up at Vrij Nederland and subsequently —together with Wim Speelman—at Trouw and later the LO. Quite soon after his contact with Ubbink, he left the Achterhoek; he became a provincial leader in Limburg and, until early 1944, the minute-taker for the Trouw weekends. In mid-April 1944, he was arrested on the train due to an error in his identity card. He tried to escape at Geldermalsen station. The SD shot him in the legs. Wounded, he was taken to Haren and, in September 1944, to Oraniënburg. A few days before the liberation in 1945, the prisoners had to be transported. Cor could not come along because of his wounded leg. The SD then shot him dead by the side of the road. Many years later, on November 22, 1966, Jo Satter saw a rerun of the TV broadcast *De Bezetting*. He looked up Cor van de Hooft's document in his papers and sent a copy of it to Dr. L. de Jong. He would use the piece in the speech with which he accepted an extraordinary professorship on September 21, 1967: “Three Dutchmen, three courageous illegal workers, have seen it. The facts themselves allow no other conclusion than that none of the three fully believed it.” The story illustrated the central idea of the speech:

chambers – not as the only ones,"Although as the most numerous group—this terrifyingly massive, terrifyingly mechanical form of destruction of human life was unbelievable to virtually all civilians in the Allied countries and the occupied territories." Yet Jo Satter will always emphatically maintain that this was not the motive for the three men in the farmhouse not to immediately pass the piece on to the Trouw editors. I think he is right about that. The more I delve into the question of what went wrong, the stronger the suspicions become of misunderstandings in the resistance communication. To begin with, the fact that the piece was not destroyed (safe), but hidden (risky), already indicates that the three apparently still had something in mind for it. According to Jo Satter, the point was indeed that they considered publication to be utterly life-threatening, primarily for the source involved. Security measures had to be taken first. Otherwise, it would have been child's play for the SD to track down the SS officer who matched the characteristics revealed in the piece. If they wanted to grant him (and his family) any chance of survival, then he had to go into hiding first. If the man refused, then there was clearly something fishy about the matter, or so the reasoning went. It was irrefutable. But there is something else entirely. What neither Ubbink nor Satter clarifies is how Cor van de Hooft managed to write such a detailed eyewitness account in the farmhouse in Sinderen. Are we really to believe that this text was transmitted orally through intermediaries? The formatting and style suggest otherwise: Cor van de Hooft simply translated a German document that Ubbink gave him to relay to England. Ubbink never knew anything about his plan to publish it in *Trouw*. The document from the chicken coop is nothing more or less than the translation of an authentic Gerstein report intended for England! In the eyewitness account itself, absolutely nothing is revealed about the first-person narrator; on the contrary. If one omits the two introductory sentences, one gets the image of an anonymous German citizen who has become disturbed by horror stories from officers in Russia and Poland. served, so an outsider. The identity of the eyewitness is revealed

statement to keep the source unidentifiable—was probably added to the piece only later. By whom? Possibly by someone who believed the statement was intended merely for transmission—in code, of course—to England. But due to the introductory sentences, the piece was no longer suitable for publication, unless the source went into hiding. The three Trouw people saw that immediately. And so the piece ended up—for the time being—under the roof tile of a chicken coop. What would have happened if Gerstein's statement had actually reached the Trouw editors? I once asked Bruins Slot, but naturally, he did not venture a statement.In 1958, Van Randwijk told Lou De Jong that fairly accurate information about Auschwitz reached him in early 1943, but that Vrij Nederland did not want to believe it. “In any case, we did not publish it. We reasoned: we are not certain that it is correct. If the reports are incorrect, we will cause enormous distress among the Jews who are in hiding here. It was a very difficult point for us.” Within the Trouw editorial staff, the situation was likely not much different at the time. Cor van de Hooft had personal contact several times in 1943 with both Smallenbroek and Bruins Slot, and according to the minutes of the weekends, members of the Trouw group often warned each other about demoralizing 'horror stories'. Gerstein later learned from Ubbink that the Dutch resistance had attached little credence to the story. In early 1949, a letter from Gerstein to Ubbink in Doesburg, which had not been sent by the hotel owner, was found in Rottweil/Neckar. When Gerstein wrote this letter to his Dutch friend, the Netherlands was still reeling from the euphoria of liberation. “Dear Friend Ubbink! You are one of the first who must receive a greeting. I may heartily congratulate you on the liberation of your country from our criminal brood of vipers. However dark our fate may be now, these hideous people were not allowed to prevail. Ask your people if they at least believe now what happened in Belzec, etc.! I am grateful to God that I did everything within my power to remove these festering sores from the body of humanity.” At the time, Kurt Gerstein still hoped to be able to testify in the trials that had been announced. Two months later, he was dead.

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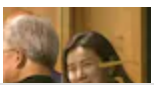
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